
PAPERBOY

WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

Six AI bosses signed a White House accord that Trump called “almost like a constitution” and “morally binding” — and which commits them to nothing measurable.

AI

Six AI bosses sign a White House accord that binds nobody

WHAT HAPPENED

At a White House lunch on Tuesday, six executives signed the [White House Accord on Super Intelligence: A Joint Commitment on Frontier AI Responsibilities](#) — Sundar Pichai, Mark Zuckerberg, Dario Amodei, Elon Musk, Jensen Huang and OpenAI president Greg Brockman, who attended in Sam Altman's place. It runs to four voluntary commitments: internal controls against cyber, bio and chemical misuse; an internal oversight team; independent external audits; and a board-level independent committee. Trump said of it, “It's almost like a constitution, in a way”, and, asked whether it was enforceable, called it “morally binding” ([CBS](#), [Washington Examiner](#)). Thirty-one guests attended, including Vance, Bessent, Nadella, Bezos, Lisa Su and Alex Karp ([Axios](#)).

WHAT IT MEANS

The industry wrote its own homework and the White House graded it pass. Four commitments with no metrics, no reporting cadence and no penalty is a press release, not a regime — the accord itself says the steps may be codified “over time”. Read it as the federal soft standard the administration can cite against state AI enforcement.

WATCH NEXT

Whether any signatory publishes the audit its own accord promises, and whether federal preemption of state AI rules follows.

Trump signs an order renaming artificial intelligence “Super Intelligence”

WHAT HAPPENED

A separate executive order, [Inaugurating the Era of Super Intelligence](#), dated 29 September, directs federal agencies to use “Super Intelligence” or “SI” instead of “Artificial Intelligence” in official correspondence, public communications, websites, reports and policy documents. It leans on the statutory definition at 15 U.S.C. 9401(3) and gives the White House science office 60 days to draft legislative language. The accompanying [fact sheet](#) says the word “artificial” undersells the technology: “The name Super Intelligence conveys the true capabilities of the technologies being developed today”. It also cites “more than \$5 billion” for the Genesis Mission — money [announced on 22 July](#) across 278 projects, not new.

WHAT IT MEANS

A vocabulary order is cheap and it is not nothing. Renaming the category as achieved superintelligence hands the industry a marketing win and retires the word that state legislatures and existing statutes are written around. Expect real argument about which term a given rule applies to.

WATCH NEXT

The OSTP legislative language, due within 60 days, and whether the term appears in the Federal Register text.

Bain: the build-out needs \$6 trillion of annual AI revenue by 2031

WHAT HAPPENED

Bain & Company's [seventh Global Technology Report](#), out 29 September, puts annual AI infrastructure spending at roughly \$1.5 trillion by 2031 and argues the industry would need about \$6 trillion of annual revenue to sustain it, with capex near 25% of revenue. Existing markets reach \$1.2–1.8 trillion on Bain's numbers, leaving roughly \$4.2 trillion to come from categories that do not exist yet — physical AI, autonomy, new advertising and search formats ([press release](#)).

WHAT IT MEANS

The gap is the story. Bain is not forecasting \$6 trillion; it is saying that is the bill, and most of it must be paid by products nobody sells today. Read this autumn's hyperscaler capex against that arithmetic.

WATCH NEXT

Hyperscaler Q3 capex guidance in late October, and whether anyone names a revenue line for the missing \$4 trillion.

Chips decouple from the bond tape

WHAT HAPPENED

The long end sold off hard on Tuesday — the 10-year Treasury closed at 5.26% and the 30-year at 5.59% ([Treasury par yield curve](#)) — and semiconductors went up anyway. The Philadelphia Semiconductor Index rose 1.32% ([Sunday Guardian](#)); the VanEck Semiconductor ETF was up about 1.5% at midday, with AI-power and optical names leading: Bloom Energy closed up roughly 11% after a Jefferies target raise on a reaffirmed Oracle fuel-cell project, and Lumentum added 5.9% ([Benzinga](#)). The broad market went the other way — S&P 500 down 0.17%, Dow down 0.26%.

WHAT IT MEANS

For two weeks the rate story has explained the chip tape better than any AI story did. Tuesday broke that, which suggests the AI capex bid is now strong enough to absorb a 5.26% risk-free rate — or that positioning is simply crowded. It is one session, so do not over-read it, but it is the first clean divergence of the month.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the SOX holds its gain through Wednesday's PCE print at 08:30 ET.

Micron reports tonight, and Korea's buyback support is running out

WHAT HAPPENED

Micron publishes FQ4 and full-year FY2026 results on Wednesday at 14:30 Mountain Time, having guided to about \$50.0bn plus or minus \$1.0bn at roughly 86% gross margin off a \$41.456bn FQ3 — the single largest test of whether memory is still the most profitable link in the AI chain. The Wednesday Asian session was mixed ahead of it: the Nikkei 225 was up 1.2% at 66,271.28 at midday and SK Hynix rose about 1.1%, while the Kospi and Samsung readings differ by the hour across outlets ([Ajupress](#), [Sunday Guardian](#)). One Korean outlet notes the Samsung and SK Hynix buybacks are nearly complete, removing a prop under Korean equities — that is a single-source claim.

WHAT IT MEANS

Memory has been carrying the semiconductor complex on pricing, not volume. If the FQ4 margin holds near 86%, the AI-capex story survives a 5.26% ten-year; if it slips, the bond market wins the argument about what discount rate this sector deserves. The Korean buyback point matters more than it sounds: mechanical bid disappearing is how a crowded trade unwinds.

WATCH NEXT

The FQ4 gross margin and HBM4 allocation commentary for 2027, tonight after the close.

FICO loses a quarter of its value in a day on a regulator's social-media post

WHAT HAPPENED

Fair Isaac closed Tuesday at \$617.87, down \$223.02 or 26.5% from \$840.89 — its worst day since 1989 ([closing data](#), [Benzinga](#)). The trigger was a post on X by FHFA director Bill Pulte, not an agency action: “Instead of two separate pricing grids, which makes zero sense, Fannie and Freddie are hereby moving to ONE PRICING GRID”, putting VantageScore alongside FICO Classic ([HousingWire](#); FHFA declined to comment to [Bloomberg Law](#), and its newsroom carries no release). Rocket Mortgage will make VantageScore 4.0 its default for eligible conforming loans in Q4 ([HousingWire](#)). TransUnion, which committed to \$0.99 VantageScore pricing through December 2028, fell 3.8%; Equifax fell 4.3%.

WHAT IT MEANS

A four-decade pricing monopoly ended in a tweet. The mechanism matters as much as the outcome: a \$9bn repricing rested on a director's personal account, with no published rule, no comment period and no docket to appeal. Any business that has priced in regulatory inertia should notice.

WATCH NEXT

Whether FHFA publishes an actual rule or guidance, and FICO's own response — it has not yet issued one.

The 10-year ties its 2007 peak and the Fed keeps talking hawkish

WHAT HAPPENED

The 10-year Treasury closed at 5.26% on 29 September, up from 5.24% the day before, matching the June 2007 closing high; the 30-year closed at 5.59% and the 20-year at 5.64% ([Treasury](#)). Intraday quotes ran to 5.29–5.30% on the 10-year and 5.61–5.62% on the 30-year, the latter the highest since 2002 ([Yahoo Finance](#), [24/7 Wall St](#)). Markets price an October 28 hike at roughly 70–72.5%. Governor Lisa Cook said “AI appears to be adding inflationary pressures”; Cleveland's Hammack warned of an entrenched “inflationary mindset”; New York's Williams called another hike before year-end “reasonable” ([Yahoo Finance](#)).

WHAT IT MEANS

Nobody on the committee is pushing back in public, which is itself the signal. A 5.26% risk-free rate with two hikes priced by December is not the world 2026 valuation models were built in — and Cook's line is the first time a governor has called AI capex inflationary rather than productive.

WATCH NEXT

August PCE Wednesday 08:30 ET, consensus +0.4% headline and +0.3% core; payrolls Friday 2 October.

Consumer confidence falls off a cliff

WHAT HAPPENED

The Conference Board's consumer confidence index fell 6.7 points in September to 81.9 from a revised 88.6, against a polled 89.2. The Present Situation Index dropped 7.9 points to 109.3 and Expectations 5.9 points to 63.6 — a third straight fall ([Conference Board](#)). Coverage called it the lowest in more than twelve years ([Axios](#)); the Board itself does not use that superlative, though it flags the first negative appraisal of current business conditions since September 2024.

WHAT IT MEANS

Expectations at 63.6 is the number to watch, not the headline. Households are being asked to absorb a hiking cycle, tariff pass-through and an AI-capex boom that has not yet shown up in their pay. That combination is how a consumer-led slowdown starts, and it sits awkwardly beside a Fed still discussing further tightening.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Friday's payrolls confirm the softening — consensus is +100,000 with unemployment at 4.2%.

OpenAI reportedly seeking \$30bn at a \$1.4 trillion valuation

WHAT HAPPENED

Bloomberg reported on Tuesday that OpenAI is in early talks to raise at least \$30bn at roughly a \$1.4 trillion valuation, with no investors named and the company declining to comment ([TechCrunch](#), [relaying Bloomberg](#)). That would mark it up from the [\\$122bn committed at an \\$852bn post-money valuation](#) announced on 31 March, led by Amazon, Nvidia and SoftBank alongside Microsoft. Run-rate revenue is reported to have risen about 70% since July to roughly \$40bn in August. This is single-outlet and talks-stage: no second newsroom has it independently, and Bloomberg's own framing is that the discussions may evolve.

WHAT IT MEANS

A 64% valuation step in six months on a private company that has already postponed its listing is a bet that the capital markets will keep funding compute ahead of cash flow. The interesting number is not \$1.4 trillion but \$30bn — roughly a quarter of the March round, which reads more like a bridge than a raise.

WATCH NEXT

Named investors, or an OpenAI confirmation. Until then treat the valuation as a report, not a fact.

Modal Labs closing roughly \$750m at \$15.75bn

WHAT HAPPENED

Accel is leading an approximately \$750m round in inference provider Modal Labs at a \$15.75bn valuation, per sources cited by [TechCrunch](#) on 28 September; [Axios Pro](#) had reported on 24 September that Accel was in talks to lead at about \$15bn. Modal was valued at \$4.65bn four months ago and passed \$300m of annualised revenue in May. Neither report is an announcement and Modal has not confirmed the terms.

WHAT IT MEANS

A 3.4x markup in four months on an inference-serving business tells you where the margin has moved: not to model builders but to whoever runs the GPUs efficiently. Two outlets converging on the same lead and roughly the same number makes this credible even unannounced.

WATCH NEXT

A formal announcement with the final number, and whether Accel's cheque is single-fund or an SPV.

Smaller rounds: agent security and supply-chain autonomy

WHAT HAPPENED

Reco raised a \$55m Series C extension led by AT&T Ventures, Forestay and Quadrille Capital, taking total funding to \$140m at an undisclosed valuation it says has more than doubled since a \$30m Series B in February. The AI-agent security company reports double-digit-millions ARR expected to triple this year, and more than 100 customers, about 40% of them in financial services ([TechCrunch](#)). Separately, a team of former Tesla engineers raised \$12.5m to automate supply-chain operations ([TechCrunch](#)).

WHAT IT MEANS

Agent security is becoming a category with a dozen funded entrants and no clear leader, which usually ends in consolidation rather than a winner. The financial-services concentration in Reco's book is the tell: regulated buyers are the ones actually paying for agent oversight, because they are the ones who have to answer for it.

WATCH NEXT

Whether any agent-security vendor lands a named hyperscaler distribution deal this quarter.

Supreme Court lets third-country deportations resume

WHAT HAPPENED

The Court granted the administration's stay application in [DHS v. D.V.D., No. 26A406](#) on 29 September, lifting a First Circuit hold on Judge Brian Murphy's injunction and allowing removals to countries not named in a migrant's removal order while the case proceeds. Justices Sotomayor, Kagan and Jackson would have denied the application; no formal dissent was filed and the order carries no recorded tally. Solicitor General D. John Sauer called third-country removal “an essential tool to remove certain aliens, including some of the worst criminal aliens”; counsel for the migrants, Trina Realmuto, warned of “prolonged and arbitrary detention, beatings and sexual assault, disappearance” ([OPB](#), [Axios](#)). Argument is set for December ([SCOTUSblog](#)).

WHAT IT MEANS

This is the third time the Court has cleared Murphy's orders out of the way, and it is now a pattern: emergency relief granted to the government, merits deferred, policy operating in the meantime. Whatever December decides, the removals happen first.

WATCH NEXT

The argument calendar for early December, and how many third-country removals occur before it.

Judge blocks FEMA from tying terror-preparedness money to election rules

WHAT HAPPENED

Judge Amir H. Ali of the federal district court in Washington blocked FEMA from conditioning counter-terrorism preparedness grants on states adopting paper ballots or verifying voter citizenship. The agency had threatened to withhold up to 20% of about \$1bn in annual grants; the plaintiffs were local governments in Tennessee, Texas and Ohio ([Philadelphia Inquirer](#)). The ruling came down Monday and was reported Tuesday.

WHAT IT MEANS

Conditioning unrelated federal money on election administration is the most portable tool in the federalism fight, because almost every jurisdiction takes some federal grant. Losing it at the district level five weeks before the midterms matters less for this money than for the precedent on every other grant stream.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the administration appeals to the D.C. Circuit, and whether other grant conditions face the same challenge.

The NIL bill's House problem

WHAT HAPPENED

S.4668, the college athlete compensation bill the Senate passed 77-22 on 28 September, has no House schedule. Majority Leader Steve Scalise is pushing the House's own version and wants the Senate to accept changes, particularly to a provision barring athletes from being classified as employees; the Congressional Black Caucus opposes the Senate text. White House officials say Trump wants to sign something before year-end ([Roll Call](#), single outlet).

WHAT IT MEANS

A 77-22 Senate vote is the easy part when the disagreement is about employment law rather than college sports. The employee-status clause is what labour groups will fight and what makes the bill worth passing to the schools, so there is no version that satisfies both chambers without someone conceding on it.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the House Energy and Commerce committee noticeably schedules a markup in October.

WORLD POLITICS

The US completes its withdrawal from Iraq

WHAT HAPPENED

The Pentagon said on Wednesday that American troops and equipment have completed what spokesman Sean Parnell called “an orderly departure from the air base in Irbil”, ending the US military presence in Iraq ([AP via KSAT](#); NPR and CNN corroborate). The Pentagon frames it as the end of a twelve-year mission against Islamic State that began in 2014, three years after the 2011 withdrawal — not as an exit from the 2003 invasion, though the two spans are being conflated in coverage. Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi presided over the handover.

WHAT IT MEANS

The counter-ISIS mission has been winding down for two years, so the date is administrative rather than dramatic. What changes is leverage: Washington now has no ground presence between Iranian-aligned militias and Iraqi politics, exactly while it negotiates with Tehran over Hormuz.

WATCH NEXT

Whether any residual advisory presence is announced, and how Iraqi militia activity changes over October.

US-Iran talks stall on Hormuz, and oil falls anyway

WHAT HAPPENED

Qatar-mediated indirect talks around the UN General Assembly ended without progress. Iran wants the Strait of Hormuz reopened within seven days, sanctions lifted, about \$12bn unfrozen and US-Israeli strikes stopped before any nuclear discussion; Trump wants everything settled in one package and has publicly rejected the Iranian sequence. Foreign Minister Araghchi: “Our discussion is clear. Right now, it is only about the Strait of Hormuz” ([Al Jazeera](#)). Crude fell regardless on signs Middle East exports are recovering: Brent settled at \$102.59, down \$2.69 or 2.6%, and WTI at \$89.38, down \$3.22 or 3.5% ([Euronext/wire](#), [Rio Times](#)).

WHAT IT MEANS

The market has stopped pricing the diplomacy and started pricing the plumbing. Two settled sessions of decline while the talks go nowhere says traders think the physical disruption is easing on its own — which, if true, removes Tehran's main piece of leverage and makes a deal less likely, not more.

WATCH NEXT

Whether a fifth round is scheduled, and whether Brent holds below \$105 on settlement.

Russia's jet-drone campaign kills nine in a night

WHAT HAPPENED

Zelenskyy said at least nine people were killed and more than eighty wounded in drone strikes across Ukraine overnight into Tuesday, three dead and nineteen injured in Dnipro — Ukrainian government figures, not independently verified. Of 120 drones launched on Monday, 90 were jet-powered and Ukraine intercepted 57% of those. A jet drone hit the National Academy of Sciences in central Kyiv on Monday, killing two. Foreign Minister Sybiha: “Russia is deliberately expanding the boundaries of what it believes the world will tolerate” ([Al Jazeera](#)).

WHAT IT MEANS

The interception rate is the story. Jet drones fly faster and higher than the Shahed pattern Ukrainian air defence was sized for, and 57% means roughly forty get through per large raid. That is a capability shift, not a bad night — and it lands while Macron's proposed double moratorium still has no Russian answer.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Ukraine's Western partners move on interceptor supply, and any Russian response to the moratorium proposal.

SOURCES

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[Benzinga](#) — AI rally defies high yields, Tuesday markets

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[TechCrunch](#) — Reco raises \$55m

[Supreme Court](#) — docket 26A406, DHS v. D.V.D.

[SCOTUSblog](#) — argument set on third-country deportations

[OPB](#) — Supreme Court allows third-country deportations to restart

[Philadelphia Inquirer](#) — court blocks FEMA election grant conditions

[Roll Call](#) — college sports bill's uncertain House path

[AP via KSAT](#) — US withdrawal from Iraq complete

[Al Jazeera](#) — where the US-Iran talks stand

[Euronext/wire](#) — oil settles down 2.5%

[Al Jazeera](#) — strike on Ukraine's Academy of Sciences